

CYBERSTALKING

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What is Cyberstalking?

Cyberstalking is a type of cybercrime that uses the internet and technology to harass or stalk a person. It can be considered an extension of cyberbullying and in-person stalking. It takes the form of text messages, e-mails, social media posts, and other mediums. Such behavior may include but is not limited to, the transmission of threats and false accusations, identity theft, data theft, damage to data or equipment, computer monitoring, the solicitation of minors for sexual purposes, and confrontation.

Types of Cyberstalking

Stalking by strangers

Cyberstalkers come in all shapes, sizes, ages, and backgrounds. They patrol Websites looking for an opportunity to take advantage of people.

Gender-based stalking or gender-based violence

It's harassment and stalking of gender online which involves posting personal information about the victim, threats of rape, and other forms of violence. It leads to the restriction of a victim's online activities, which can interfere with their autonomy and involvement in online life.

Cyberstalking of intimate partners

Cyberstalking is a type of online harassment that targets a former or current intimate partner. Its purpose is to control the victim in order to create dependency and social isolation. Harassers may send repeated insulting or threatening e-mails to their victims and send them messages that are not related to their victims' interests.

Cyberstalking of celebrities and public persons

As part of the risk they take for being in the public eye, celebrities and public figures are often targets of lies or made-up stories in tabloids as well as by stalkers, some even seeming to be fans.

Cyberstalking by anonymous online mobs

Technologies has enabled online groups of anonymous people to self-organize to target individuals with online defamation, threats of violence, and technology-based attacks.

Corporate cyberstalking

Corporate cyberstalking is when a company harasses an individual online, or an individual or group of individuals harasses an organization. Reasons for corporate cyberstalking are a desire for financial gain or revenge.

Examples

Catfishing: *The creation of fake profiles or copying of existing ones on social media to approach victims*

Monitoring check-ins on social media: *Adding location check-ins to your Facebook and Instagram posts.*

Spying via Google Maps and Google Street View: *Using Street View to spy on a victim and find their location from posts or photos on social media.*

Hijacking webcam: *Webcams can be hijacked by introducing malware-infected files into*

the victim's computer

Tracking location with geotags: *Digital pictures mostly have geotagged with the time and location of the picture if it is in the metadata format, which makes it easier for stalkers to access that information by using special apps.*

Cyberstalking Statistics

According to Law Enforcement Technology, cyberstalking has increased with the growth of new technology and new ways to stalk victims. 200,000 people are real stalkers in America, approximately 1 in 1250 persons. 90% of the victims are women and 95% of stalkers are men. A 2016 report from the Data & Society Research Institute finds that most U.S. internet users have witnessed online harassment.

1. Online harassment varies by gender

According to Pew Research, women are more likely to experience online sexual harassment or cyberstalking than men. Of these, 26% of women aged 18–24 experienced a high number of incidents, with 26% having been cyberstalked and 25% being the target of sexual harassment.

2. Young people experience harassment even more

About 65 percent of Internet users aged 18 to 29 have experienced some type of online harassment. Some of the harassment included physical threats, sexual harassment, and harassment over a long period of time.

3. Identity is often hidden

About half of those who are harassed online don't know who is behind the threats or harassment.

4. Social media plays the largest role

About 66 percent of harassed people said it occurred on social media. People also used email, discussion sites, and online gaming sites to harass people.

Cyberstalking and Laws

The first anti-stalking statute was enacted in California in 1990, and stalking research has been expanded immensely. In the US, nearly every state has laws that address cyberstalking or cyberbullying. A conviction can result in restraining order, probation, or criminal penalties against the assailant, including jail.

In Tunisia, the Tunisian Council of Ministers approved, On May 1, 2018, a draft "cybercrime" law that aims to "prevent and combat cyber crimes of information and communication."

Tunisians Reject New Cybercrime Law And Consider It A Restriction Of Freedoms.

Cyberstalking VS Online Harassment

In law, a distinction is often drawn between the two: according to the National Conference of State Legislatures, online harassment is typically defined as "not involving a credible threat", whereas threat is present in cyberstalking.

How to Cope With Cyberstalking?

**Make it clear to the cyberstalker that you don't want to be contacted and warn them that if they continue, you'll go to the police with copies of any communications involved, including your own, and emails from the networks.*

**If you think someone is tracking you through spyware, don't use your own computer or phone to get help - borrow a family or friend's phone.*

**Change all your passwords.*

**In the case of social media stalking, use your privacy settings to block the person, and then report the abuse to the network.*

**If you have been sent abusive or threatening emails, you probably know the stalker's ISP - the bit after the @ in their email address. There's a reporting mechanism you can use at https://support.google.com/mail/contact/abuse.*

**You can filter abusive emails to a separate folder so that you don't have to read them.*

**If you think the cyberstalker might harass you in the workplace, tell your employer.*

How to Prevent Cyberstalking?

Digital hygiene

-Use a VPN when on public WiFi

-Logging off all applications

-Browsing anonymously with a private browser.

-Upgrade your software and install an antivirus.

Strengthen your privacy settings

-Disable your geolocation settings

-Change your Facebook privacy settings and update your Instagram privacy settings.

-Stay up to date on the best security and privacy extensions for Google Chrome.

-Create strong, unique passwords for all your online accounts.

-Beware of installing apps that want access to your Facebook or other contact lists

Check what is being published about you online

Remove personal information from the internet and google yourself. If you see something you don't like, you can request Google remove it from their search results.

Impact of Stalking on Victims

Cyberstalking is no different than stalking and leads to consequences that can be detrimental to the victims both physically and mentally. Cyberstalking affects the overall well-being of victims. They often suffer from anxiety, distress, depression, PTSD, and suicidal ideation.

Effects on mental health:

**Denial, confusion*

**Frustration*

**Guilt, embarrassment, self-blame*

Effects on physical health:

**Effects of chronic stress including headaches, hypertension*

**Gastrointestinal problems*

**Impact on health of increased use of alcohol, cigarettes or drugs*

Effects on social life:

**Victims move to a new location, change phone number, name or even their look .*

**Isolation, feeling misunderstood*

**Insecurity and inability to trust others impacting current and future relationships and friendships.*

Survey method

The analysis in this report is based on an online survey conducted from 13/10/2022 to 17/10/2022 among a sample of 55 individuals of adults, 18 years of age or older, and teenagers. Respondents are from different areas: we published the questionnaire on Facebook pages and groups, on Whatsapp and we sent it to our friends. The questionnaire was conducted anonymously, with no email addresses of the respondents. It included the age, gender, and status of the respondents.

The survey is composed of 15 questions, including multiple-choice questions, Yes/No questions, and open-ended questions.

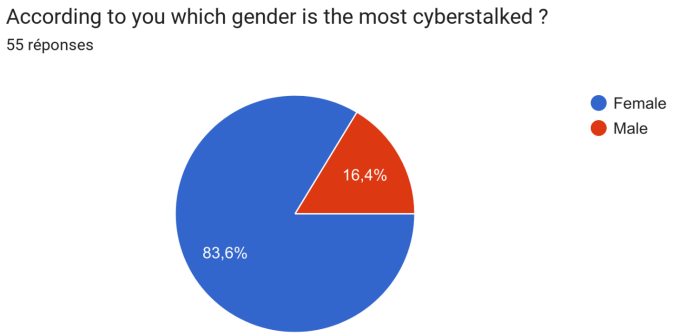
The goal of this survey was to calculate the prevalence by age and gender of cyberstalking and to measure attitudes toward this phenomenon.

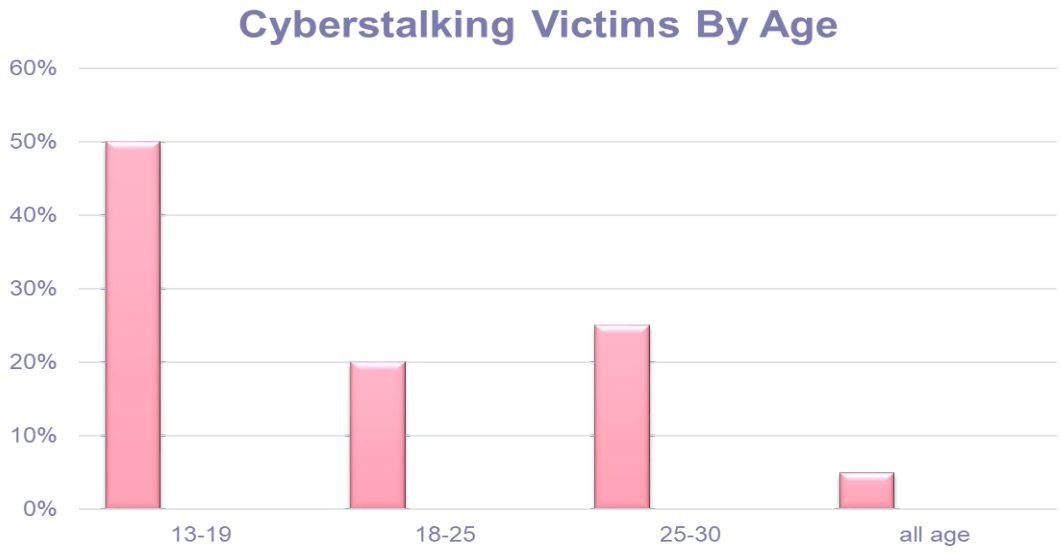
We found that 72.7% interested in this subject are female while only 27.3% are male. The majority were aged between 19-22 while the minority were aged between 31-40. More than half of the respondents are university students, 23.6% are employees, and 12.7% are high school students.

Feature	Number	Percentage
Female	40	72.7%
Male	20	27.3%
15-18	7	12.7%
19-22	29	52.7%
23-30	13	23.6%
31-40	6	10.9%
High school student	7	12.7%
University student	35	63.6%
Employee	13	23.6%

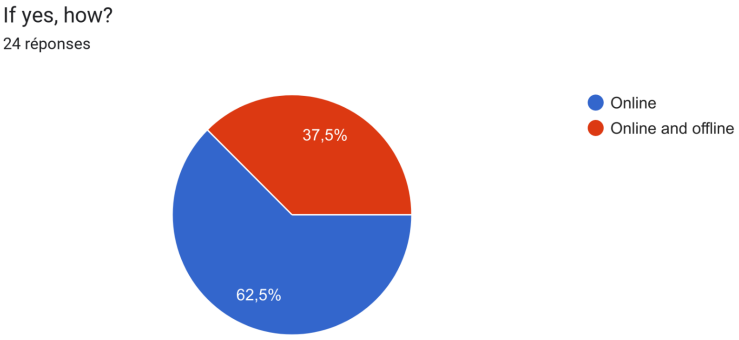
Survey Results

Our findings from the survey for cyberstalking revealed the following results:

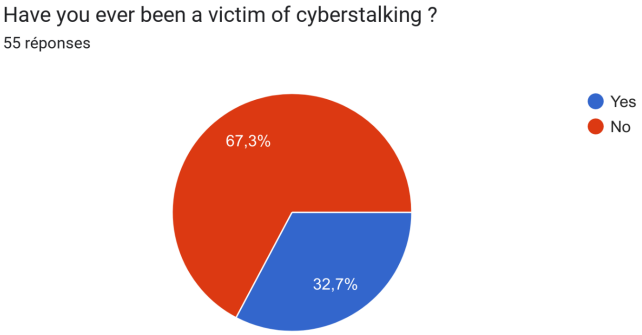


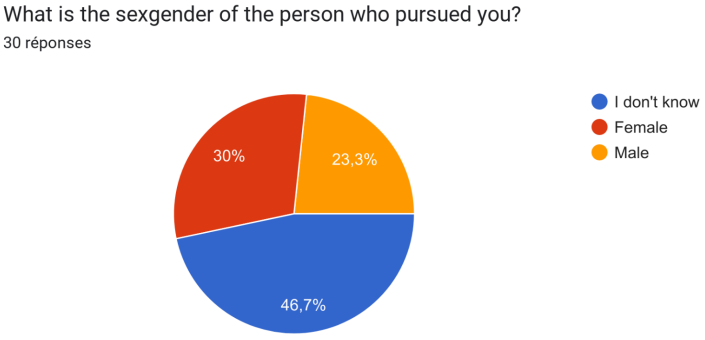


=>The most common response was that victims of cyberstalking are aged between 13 and 18 years old. Women admitted greater frequencies of cyberstalking perpetration than males.

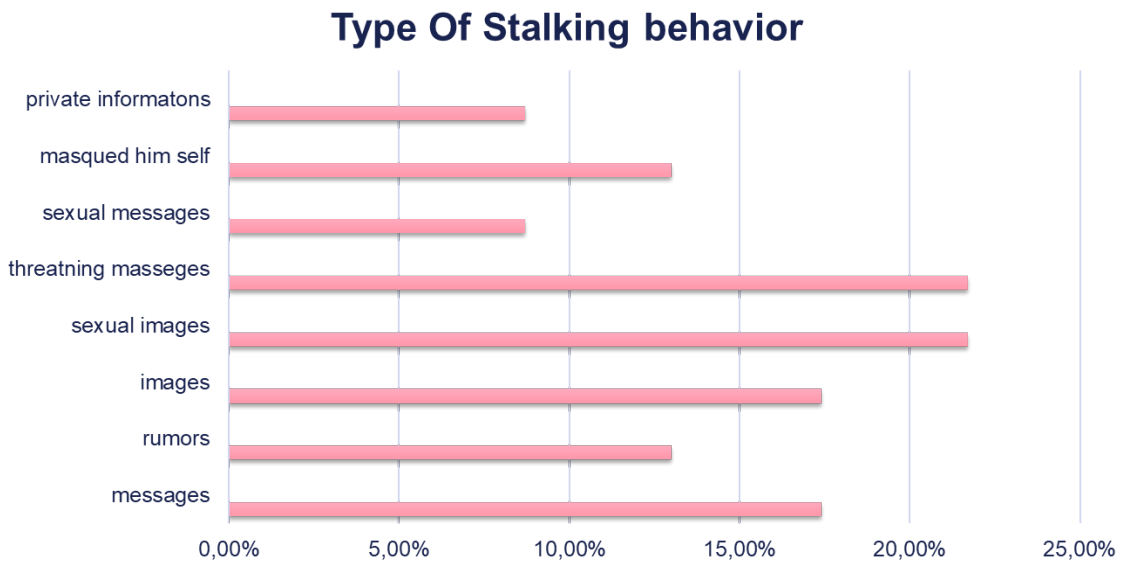


=>32.7% of respondents were victims of cyberstalking. Two-thirds of them were just online cyberstalked and one-third were online and offline cyber stalked. While 62.5% of the respondents have never been victims of cyberstalking..





. The gender of the harasser is often unknown/ Anonyme with a proportion of 46.7%. However, females are more involved(30%)than males in being cyberstalked.



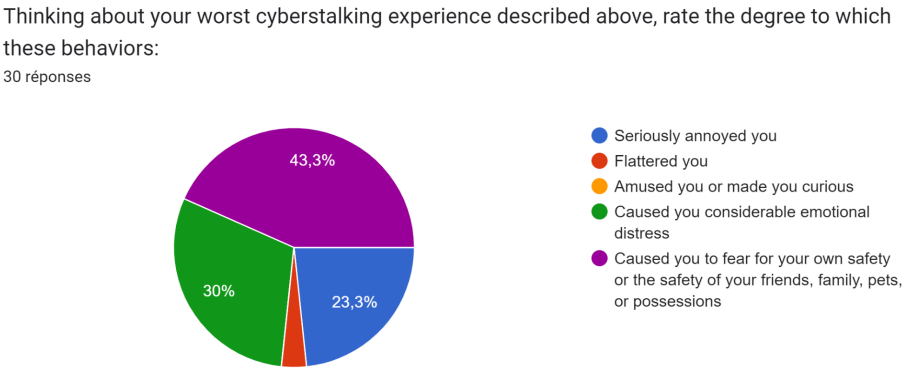
The most prevalent type of stalking:

-Sending messages that directly or indirectly threatened to harm you, your family, your friends, etc. (25%)

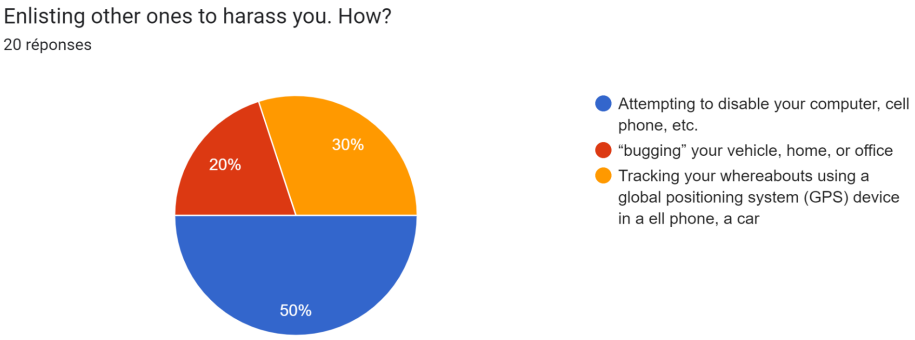
-Sending pornographic/obscene images or messages that seem targeted. (20.8%)

-Sending messages that inappropriately shared information about the sender's life, family, hobbies, etc. (16.7%)

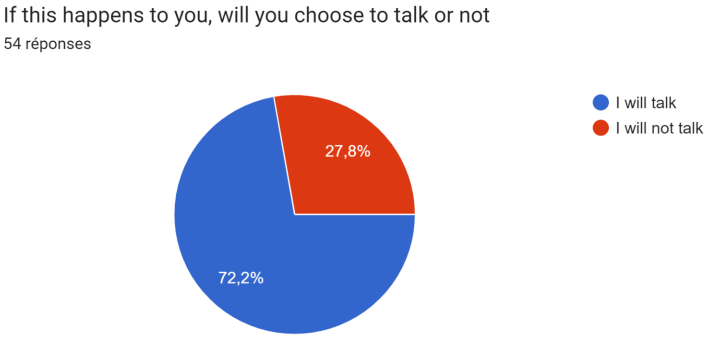
-Posting or circulating images of you without your consent (16.7%)



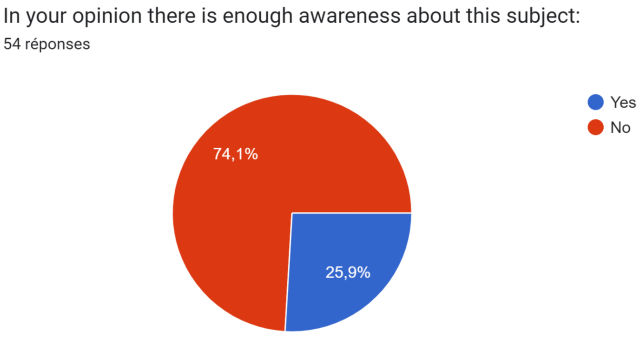
=>43.3% of victims said that the stalking behavior caused them to fear for their own safety of their friends, family, pets, or possessions.30% caused them considerable emotional distress and 23.3%seriously annoyed them



=>About one-third of stalking victims have suffered from dangerous types of cyberstalking as listed in the diagram above.



72.2% of people approved that they will talk if they are victims of cyberstalking which is a good number compared to those who won't talk.



=>74.1% of people agreed that there is not enough awareness about cyberstalking.

=>According to respondents, the main cause behind the silence of the victims is being embarrassed by people's reactions.

=>The common solutions suggested by the respondents are spreading awareness and making new cyber laws.

Appendices

https://docs.google.com/forms/d/1XLIuuZU25x-UTjYwekE9XgbY6bUa2Dw3l9DdD_yoQMw/prefill